disturbing news. Its bearer, as before, was the CIA imagery intelligence expert Arthur Lundahl, who had presented the U-2 photographs to Kennedy two days earlier.

Shortly after 11:00 a.m. on October 18, Lundahl told the president and his advisers that a U-2 camera had detected a launch complex approximately 20 miles southwest of Havana. Its presence suggested the deployment of intermediate-range ballistic missiles (IRBMs) whose range was roughly twice that of the previously spotted MRBMs. “We have never identified, irrevocably, the signature of the Soviet intermediate range ballistic missile, which is estimatedly a 2,000 mile missile,” declared Lundahl. “But the elongation of the pads and location of the control bunkers, between each pair of pads, has been the thing that suggested to our hearts, if not our minds, the kind of thing that might accompany an IRBM.” Whatever was preoccupying the minds of those present, Lundahl’s information was grim enough to make their hearts sink. Lundahl told Kennedy: “[T]he orientation of the axis of the pads, 315 [degrees] … will bring you into the central massif of the United States.”[4]

The news that the Soviets were bringing to Cuba intermediate-range missiles covering the better part of the United States strengthened John Kennedy’s advocacy of an unannounced strike on the Soviet missile installations. He had taken that position during the first day of the crisis. “President seemed inclined to act promptly if at all, without warning, targeting on MRBM’s and possible airfields,” wrote McCone in his note on the meeting with Kennedy that day. “Stated Congressional resolutions gave him all authority he needed, and this was confirmed by Bundy, and therefore seemed inclined to act.”[5]

Lundahl’s report had a profound impact on those in the room. Dean Rusk, who had earlier opposed Kennedy’s surgical strike option, was now ready to join the president: “I think this changes my thinking on the matter,” said Rusk before declaring himself in favor of the strike. But he wanted it to be preceded by a warning. “We all of course remember *The Guns of August*, where certain events brought about a general situation which at the time none of the governments involved really wanted,” remarked Rusk, referring to Barbara Tuchman’s examination of Europe’s sleepwalking into World War I. He knew about Kennedy’s fascination with the book and clearly